PUNJAB

BJP'S LEADERSHIP VOID

Arvind Khanna's return to the Akali Dal exposes the fragility of the saffron side—short on credible faces and struggling to align central strategy with local realities

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

THE QUIET HOMECOMING OF ARVIND KHANNA, until recently the BJP's Punjab vice-president, was more than a routine political defection. Received by Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president and childhood friend Sukhbir Singh Badal, Khanna rejoined the party where he began his political career in the 1990s. Badal has appointed him *halqa* (assembly segment) in-charge of Sangrur, widely seen as positioning him for the 2027 state election.

Khanna's exit highlights a deeper structural weakness within the BJP's state unit: the absence of a leader with mass legitimacy or emotional resonance. Once an Akali youth leader, Khanna later moved to the Congress, then led by his cousin, Capt. Amarinder Singh, and won the assembly election from Sangrur in 2002, Dhuri in 2012. In 2015, he abruptly resigned from the assembly, announcing his retirement from politics. The pause proved temporary: he joined the BJP in 2022 and unsuccessfully contested the assembly and Lok Sabha elections from Sangrur.

URBAN-RURAL DIVIDE

In private conversations, Khanna has acknowledged that the BJP's inability to break into Punjab's rural belt influenced his decision. In the November bypoll to the rural Tarn Taran assembly segment, the BJP candidate secured barely 6,200 votes and forfeited his deposit.

Largely urban in character, the party has struggled to gain traction in the rural heartland that often determines electoral outcomes. Its strategy appears to hinge on projecting itself as pro-Panthic without alienating its Hindu urban base—a delicate balance, given its uneven engagement with Punjab's enduring wounds. These range from grudges over Operation Bluestar and the handling of militancy to the long shadow of the state's 1966 reorganisation, and, more recently, residual anger after the farm law agitation and sacrilege controversies. Even disputes over Chandigarh and river waters reinforce a perception that the BJP remains out of step with Punjab's pulse.

For now, the organisational response has centred on prominent Jat faces: Ravneet Singh Bittu, who got a Union ministerial berth despite losing Ludhiana; state president Sunil Jakhar, who continues in the role with visible reluctance; and Rajya Sabha MP Satnam Sandhu. Yet, none seems equipped to bridge the gap between Delhi's strategic calculus and Punjab's realities.

After switching sides, Khanna called for reviving an Akali Dal–BJP alliance—an idea also advocated by Jakhar and Amarinder. But none commands a constituency within the RSS network or the state BJP's old guard. Badal himself faces a credibility crisis, leading some observers to argue that the BJP should allow him space to rebuild while it continues its solitary expansion.

The disconnect between the central leadership and the state unit has surfaced repeatedly. Since the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Jakhar has skipped organisational meetings. In July last year, the BJP appointed former state



FULL CIRCLE Sukhbir Badal welcomes Arvind Khanna to the Shiromani Akali Dal, Sangrur, Feb. 15